

Brand authenticity, its conceptualization, and its relevance to nonprofit marketing

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Received: 27 September 2016 / Accepted: 12 February 2017

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Abstract The conceptualization of brand authenticity as evidenced from the extent literature is examined for validity issues. The body of literature on brand authenticity has produced a fragmented and varied theory of the construct and the value of knowledge produced from this research stream is questionable. This is problematic for researchers working on nonprofit marketing topics that investigate brand authenticity as a construct of interest. In the literature, brand authenticity has been defined in a variety of ways, typically as a multidimensional construct. As many as 40 different dimensions were found in our literature search. At the conclusion of our analysis, we present brand authenticity as a unidimensional construct that refers to the degree to which a brand object is perceived to be the quintessential exemplar of its type. This definition of brand authenticity is most consistent with the denotative meaning of the term and is suited to all types of brand objects including nonprofit organizations.

Keywords Brand authenticity · Theory construction · Construct definition

1 Introduction

In the commercial sector, the growth in the number of brands and rapid imitation of competitor product innovations have led to high levels of product similarity. Brand managers are attempting to remain competitive by finding ways to maintain brand distinctiveness and finding ways of evoking strengthening brand preference (Gilmore and Pine 2007). In the nonprofit sector, branding has become a major managerial mindset for nonprofit executives and influences their strategic and tactical decisions (Kylander and Stone 2012).

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Brand authenticity is a relatively recent brand concept that is receiving increased attention in the literature because it may be useful in helping brands remain competitive (Beverland 2005a, b; Blackshaw 2008; Eggers et al. 2013). Nonprofit managers view brand authenticity has a means of influencing perceived brand experience (Bennett et al. 2013). Despite brand authenticity's potential importance in the competitive brand marketplace, "...the concept of brand authenticity has not been thoroughly examined in academic marketing research so far" (Schallehn et al. 2014, p. 192).

Brand management is becoming even more important in the nonprofit sector (Michel and Rieunier 2012; Wymer 2013b). Nonprofit managers are recognizing the importance of distinguishing their organizations by managing their organizations as brands (Laidler-Kylander and Stenzel 2013; Wymer et al. 2015). Nonprofit managers continue to search for ways to gain notoriety and favorable reputations in order to attract support (e.g., donations and volunteers) in an increasingly competitive environment (Stride and Lee 2007; Wymer and Rundle-Thiele 2016). In some nonprofit sectors (like arts and culture areas) ensuring an authentic patron experience is viewed as a fundamental requirement of nonprofit brand survival (Bennett et al. 2013). Nonprofit organizations involved in tourism are increasingly concerned about brand authenticity (Correia and Brito 2014; Stoykova 2015). Nonprofit organizations involved in rebranding strategies are concerned about maintaining the authenticity of their brands (Lee 2013).

In spite of the interest in brand authenticity, the construct's development in the scholarly literature has been problematic. The conceptualizations of brand authenticity lack sufficient precision to delineate the actual meaning of the construct (Wymer 2016). Some authors' have had an applied research perspective of brand authenticity (c.f., Assiouras et al. 2015; Beverland 2005a). Hence, brand authenticity was conceptualized and measured in a limited industry context. As a consequence, the brand authenticity literature has become fragmented and inconsistent. The conceptualization of brand authenticity has not achieved a consensus in the literature as there are multiple perceptions of the construct as well as multiple measures.

If the conceptualization of brand authenticity lacks validity, then measures of brand authenticity are invalid. Research relying on misconceptualizations of constructs or invalid measures of those constructs are suspect and add little to our knowledge (Summers 2001). The purpose of this paper, then, is to develop a valid conceptualization of brand authenticity that can be useful to researchers and enhance the validity of research on this important construct. By providing a valid conceptualization of brand authenticity, valid measures can be developed and future research can add to our knowledge.

To attain the objective of this paper, our analysis will begin by deriving a semantic understanding of authenticity. We will combine an examination of the etymology of the term an examination of how the term is used in the literature. We will then examine the validity of the various conceptualizations of brand authenticity in the marketing literature. At the conclusion of this analysis, a reconceptualization of brand authenticity will be offered. A more valid conceptualization of brand authenticity should help researchers arrive at a consensus on its meaning, help them develop a valid measure of brand authenticity, reducing continued fragmentation in the literature, and enhance the validity of future research on this construct.

2 Understanding authenticity

The conceptualization of a construct should begin by deriving the root meaning of the construct's name from its denotation (Wymer 2013a). This practice helps to reduce the invalidation of construct conceptualizations because of researchers' biases (Wymer and Alves 2013).

Authenticity refers to the degree to which an object is real or genuine (not a copy or a fake), and is a representation of its true nature (Dictionary.com 2016). Since brand authenticity, by definition, refers to the level of authenticity of an object (the brand), brand authenticity refers to the degree to which the brand is perceived to be original (rather than a copy of a more authentic brand) (Peterson 2005). Brand object refers to the entity that is the target of brand identification (Wymer 2013b).

It is unlikely that the quality being authentic is inherently advantageous to a brand. If there is a managerial benefit of brand authenticity, it is likely dependent upon the brand's strength. For example, the first entrant of a brand in the marketplace is original and, by definition, authentic. However, if a subsequent competitor's brand is much more preferred by consumers than the authentic brand, being authentic yields little benefit for the category pioneer. Conversely, if competitors' brands are viewed by consumers as inferior versions of the authentic brand, then authenticity may be perceived as a desirable brand attribute. Hence, it is reasonable to believe that the influence of brand authenticity on brand preference (or other desirable outcome variable) is moderated by brand strength (Wymer 2015).

Brand managers may make changes to a brand object over time. New features may be added. Logos may be redesigned. The degree to which changes to a brand affects its perceived brand authenticity is likely dependent upon the degree to which the changes are perceived to be imitatively-influenced. That is, if a brand is changed in such a way that is more closely resembles another brand than before the change, it is likely that the change will reduce the perceived brand authenticity.

An important issue in the conceptualization of brand authenticity concerns the degree to which a brand is perceived to be the exemplar, or quintessence, of its kind. A brand exemplar is the brand that is the model from which competitor brands are patterned or compared. Does an authentic brand have to be the first, original object of its type (the prototype); does it have to be the *de facto* brand exemplar; or does it have to be both?

As an illustrative example, the IBM Simon Personal Communicator was the first or original smartphone (IBM Simon 2016). However, the Apple iPhone is, by far, the dominant brand and is considered the quintessential smartphone (Vance 2015). Either the Simon or the iPhone is the most authentic. Simon is the category pioneer (the first of its kind), whereas the iPhone is the exemplar or quintessential smartphone. Being authentic implies that the brand is perceived to be real, true, and not a copy of something else. We think it is reasonable to believe that quintessence is more indicative of authenticity than pioneer status. Apple, the maker of the iPhone, is one of the most authentic global brands according to a recent survey of 12,000 consumers in 14 countries (Nanji 2016). It is the smartphone brand that sets the standard to which competing brands are compared. The iPhone appears to be perceived as the *real* (authentic) smartphone.

We will examine the importance of exemplar status to the brand authenticity construct further in our subsequent analysis of the literature. We will evaluate the various ways in which brand authenticity has been conceptualized and used in the extant literature. Because scholarly work on brand authenticity has become fragmented rather than achieving coherence and consensus (Akbar 2016; Coary 2013), it is valuable to examine the relative validity of brand authenticity in the literature. The objective is to arrive at the most valid conceptualization of the construct so that future work on brand authenticity can result in more valid knowledge. This is especially important for nonprofit marketing researchers who are often faced with validity issues when using constructs first developed in the general marketing literature.

3 Analysis of brand authenticity in the literature

Based on our prior discussion, we will tentatively offer the following definition of brand authenticity. Brand authenticity refers to the degree to which a brand is perceived to be the quintessential exemplar of its type. Hence, this conceptualization of brand authenticity is likely unidimensional and would be measured as a continuous variable. Next, we will examine how the extant literature has conceptualized brand authenticity. Reviews of the brand authenticity literature have been reported previously (Akbar 2016; Coary 2013). Hence, we will not review the body of literature on brand authenticity but will, instead, analyze how the construct has been conceptualized in the literature.

Our previous tentative definition for brand authenticity conceives the construct as unidimensional. A unidimensional construct refers to a distinct unitary concept whereas a multidimensional construct is a concept which is formed by combining other, lower-order, concepts. For example, socioeconomic status (a multidimensional construct) is formed by combining wealth, income, occupation, and education. Occupation (a unidimensional construct) refers to one's job classification.

With respect to the dimensionality of brand authenticity, in the prior literature it has been presented as a multidimensional construct. There is not a defense in the literature of the need to conceive brand authenticity as a multidimensional construct. However, if it is a multidimensional construct then a brand object must have the dimensional traits in order to be perceived to be authentic. That is, the relationship between the dimensions and the higher order construct, brand authenticity is, by definition, formative.

A relatively common facet in the literature on brand authenticity is that the construct is often not defined as a unidimensional construct, but as a multidimensional construct. Brand authenticity is then defined in the literature in terms of its purported dimensions. Unfortunately, the dimensionality of brand authenticity varies between authors.

For example, in Akbar (2016), the following dimensions of brand authenticity (see Table 1) were found in the literature. There is little consistency among authors regarding which dimensions are the true dimensions that form the construct. (Information on the literature search methodologies from which the findings in Table 1 were based is contained in Appendix A.)

As the reader can readily discern, brand authenticity has been described in numerous ways. Authors appear to define brand authenticity to suit the context of their studies. What is needed, then, is a thorough analysis of the various brand authenticity

Table 1 Brand authenticity dimensions found in the literature [Akbar (2016)]

Name of dimension	Definition	Key citations
Adhering to principles	It refers to faithfulness to internal values and mission statement, and truthfulness with customers.	Coary (2013)
Beautiful	It refers to whether the brand has an emphasis on harmony and aesthetics.	Boyle (2004)
Being the category pioneer	It refers to being first in the market or inventor of the product.	Coary (2013)
Congruency	It refers to how individual [employee] values and brand values are congruous and how employees are committed to fulfill value requirements.	Eggers et al. (2013)
Consistency	It refers to whether promises made to stakeholders are aligned with its values and strategies to achieve consistency amongst all brand elements (concerning operations, communications, staff, etc.).	Eggers et al. (2013)
Continuity	It refers to a brand's stability, endurance, and consistency. It refers to a brand's timelessness, historicity, and ability to transcend trends.	Bruhn et al. (2012); Morhart et al. (2014)
Credibility	It refers to the brand's transparency and honesty towards the consumer, as well as its willingness and ability to fulfill the claims it makes.	Morhart et al. (2014)
Customer orientation	It refers to whether brand understands and satisfies the customers' and stakeholders' needs by providing "individualized benefits", as promised.	Eggers et al. (2013)
Declared beliefs	It refers to whether the brand stands for more than just making money.	Authentic Brand Index (2008)
Downplaying commercial motives	It refers to whether the brand stands for something more than its commercial success.	Beverland (2006)
Ethical	It refers to whether the organization and its products can be trusted.	Boyle (2004)
Familiarity	It refers to whether the brand is well known.	Authentic Brand Index (2008)
Heritage and pedigree	It refers to whether the brand has a distinguished heritage and maintains its traditions. It refers to whether the brand has an engaging story. It refers to whether the brand builds on long-held traditions and timeless design, and whether it has a strong link to the past.	Authentic Brand Index (2008); Beverland (2006, 2009); Napoli et al. (2014)
Honest	It refers to whether the brand avoids all forms of dishonesty.	Boyle (2004)
Human	It refers to whether humanity is emphasized by the brand.	Boyle (2004)

Table 1 (continued)

Name of dimension	Definition	Key citations
Integrity	It refers to the moral purity and responsibility of a brand towards its customers.	Morhart et al. (2014)
Maintaining the original product	It refers to whether the brand maintains its original product(s) without a compromise.	Coary (2013)
Method of production	It refers to whether the brand maintains exacting production processes with the help of devoted and skilled people.	Beverland (2006)
Momentum	It refers to whether the brand appears to become ever more popular.	Authentic Brand Index (2008)
Natural	It refers to whether the brand has a preference for natural processes and materials.	Boyle (2004); Gilmore and Pine (2007)
Naturalness	It refers to a brand's impression of genuineness, realness, and lack of artificiality.	Bruhn et al. (2012)
Originality	It refers to whether the brand has introduced something new and unique to the market. It refers to a brand's particularity, individuality, and innovativeness.	Authentic Brand Index (2008); Bruhn et al. (2012); Gilmore and Pine (2007)
Personal utility	It refers to whether the customers feel that they cannot live without the real utility delivered by the brand.	Authentic Brand Index (2008)
Quality commitment	It refers to whether the brand has uncompromising quality commitment. It refers to whether stringent quality standards are maintained by the brand while employing the finest materials and craftsmanship.	Beverland (2006, 2009); Napoli et al. (2014)
Relationship to place	It refers to whether the brand is rooted in a region, which has a unique reputation to be celebrated and aims to celebrate it.	Beverland (2006)
Reliability	It refers to a brand's trustfulness, credibility, and keeping promises.	Bruhn et al. (2012)
Rooted	It refers to whether the brand is connected to a place and time of origin.	Boyle (2004)
Simple	It refers to whether the brand minimizes complexity.	Boyle (2004)
Sincerity	It refers to whether the brand tries not to let people down. It refers to whether the brand refuses to compromise its values and principles.	Authentic Brand Index (2008); Napoli et al. (2014)
Stylistic consistency	It refers to whether the brand follows its production traditions consistently, and does not compromise to appear trendy or fashionable.	Beverland (2006)
Sustainable		Boyle (2004)

Table 1 (continued)

Name of dimension	Definition	Key citations
	It refers to whether the brand wants a “better tomorrow”, and is not exclusively focused on today.	
Symbolism	It refers to the symbolic quality of a brand that consumers can use to define who they are or who they are not.	Morhart et al. (2014)
Three-dimensional	It refers to whether the brand provides deep and vivid experiences.	Boyle (2004); Gilmore and Pine (2007)
Unspun	It refers to whether the brand is candid and not manipulative.	Boyle (2004)

dimensions so that a more valid conceptualization of the construct can emerge and be used consistently in the future. Otherwise, the knowledge of this construct and its relationships with other constructs will not be valid and little knowledge will be discovered from research on this topic.

Brand authenticity refers to how authentic a brand object is perceived by some audience of interest. Hence, brand authenticity is a perceived trait of a brand object. The brand object, the entity that is branded, needs to be distinguished from the organization that is marketing the brand object. There is a theoretical conflation in the literature between the perceived authenticity of a brand object and the authenticity of the organization that markets the brand object.

It may be that case that an organization is a brand object, but this is not always the case. A valid conceptualization of brand authenticity should not confuse the marketing organization with the brand object. Four of the brand authenticity dimensions used in the literature and presented in Table 1 (adhering to principles, congruency, consistency, and ethical) refer to the organization that is managing the brand rather than to the brand object. Hence, the validity of these four dimensions is questionable.

We have previously discussed the issue of whether or not category pioneer status was a requirement for brand authenticity. Sometimes a category pioneer is launched before its time (a market segment is ready to adopt it) or the category pioneer is supplanted by a more successful competitor that becomes the category exemplar. The “being the category pioneer” dimension from Table 1, therefore, appears to have questionable validity.

An important issue when considering the validity of brand-related constructs pertains to the applicability of the construct across brand object types. If a brand object may be imbued with a given characteristic, then having that characteristic should be a possibility across the various types of brand objects. If a brand object can be perceived to be authentic, then it should be possible for all types of brand objects to be perceived to be authentic. We know from the literature that many entities (i.e., brand objects) can be branded; such as goods, services, people, ideas, places, and organizations (Wymer 2013b).

Unfortunately, some brand authenticity dimensions that have been used in prior work violate this principle. Some authors’ conceptualizations of brand authenticity

were biased by their inability to consider the construct outside their research context. Maintaining the original product (see Table 1), for example, assumes that the brand object is a product. Method of production, natural, quality commitment, and stylistic consistency assume that the brand object is a manufactured product. The validity of these dimensions is questionable.

One potential validity error authors may make is to confound an antecedent of a construct as a dimension of the construct (Summers 2001). For a construct to be a dimension of a higher order construct, its meaning must be contained within the conceptual domain of the higher order construct. If construct A has relationship with construct B but its meaning is not contained within the conceptual domain of construct B, then construct A is not a dimension of construct B. Hence, construct A may be an antecedent, mediator, moderator, or consequent of construct B; but it is not a dimension of construct B.

The best way to avoid confounding an antecedent of a construct as a dimension of the construct is to make sure that the proposed dimension's meaning is contained within the denotative meaning of the construct. In the extant literature on brand authenticity, some authors have added dimensions which appear to have no semantic relationship to the denotative meaning of authenticity. Hence, adding a dimension to the conceptualization of a construct in which the added dimension does not belong in the conceptual domain of the construct weakens construct validity.

The dimension, personal utility, is an example of this validity error. Personal utility (see Table 1) refers to whether customers feel that they cannot live without the real utility delivered by the brand (Authentic Brand Index 2008). It is not apparent how this concept of personal utility is related to brand authenticity. Perhaps brand authenticity has some influence on one's subsequent feelings of attachment or identification with a brand (an antecedent-consequent relationship in the nomological net), but personal utility does not appear to belong within the semantic meaning (conceptual domain) of brand authenticity. Furthermore, since a construct's dimension has a formative relationship with the construct, the theoretical implication of including personal utility as a dimension of brand authenticity is that one must feel that one cannot live without a brand for one to perceive the brand as authentic. This is a flawed theory of brand authenticity and, hence, personal utility should not be conceived as a brand authenticity dimension.

The validity error of adding a dimension to a construct's conceptual domain in which the dimension's semantic meaning is not contained within the semantic meaning of the higher order construct is manifest in the brand authenticity literature. The dimensions (see Table 1): continuity, credibility, customer orientation, declared beliefs, and downplaying commercial motives are examples of this type of validity error.

An examination of the dimension, familiarity, provides an illustrative example of this type of validity error. Familiarity refers to whether the brand is well known (Authentic Brand Index 2008). First, the definition of familiarity is flawed because it frames familiarity as a categorical variable instead of a continuous variable. The dimension should be redefined to refer to the degree to which a brand is well known to a target audience. In any event, brand familiarity shares a relationship with brand authenticity, to be sure. One has to have some level of familiarity with a brand before one can evaluate the extent to which a brand is authentic. However, although brand familiarity is a necessary

prerequisite of brand authenticity, this does not qualify it as a dimension of brand authenticity, but as an antecedent. Hence, there is a relationship between brand familiarity and brand authenticity, but the relationship exists external to the conceptual domain of brand authenticity (antecedent-consequent in the nomological net).

The dimension, heritage and pedigree, does not appear to exist within the conceptual domain of authenticity as denoted in the language. The dimension, human, does not appear to exist within the conceptual domain of authenticity (and, by definition, cannot qualify as a dimension of authenticity). Human, which refers to whether humanity is emphasized by the brand, may not even exist within the nomological net of brand authenticity. Integrity, momentum, relationship to place, reliability, rooted, simple, sincerity, sustainable, symbolism, three-dimensional, and unspun all appear to violate the principle that a dimension must exist within the conceptual domain of its higher order construct. If these alleged dimensions did exist within the conceptual domain of brand authenticity, then a brand could not be perceived to be authentic without them. Each of these dimensions may have some relationship with brand authenticity and, therefore, may exist within brand authenticity's nomological net. However, none of these dimensions appears to be a semantic component of brand authenticity. The best way to avoid this validity error is to require a proposed dimension to be a semantic component of the higher order construct's denotative meaning.

The brand authenticity dimension, honest (see Table 1), deserves greater scrutiny. Brand authenticity implies that the brand is not a copy of something else, but is itself the exemplar from which copies are based. The honest dimension refers to whether the brand avoids all forms of dishonesty (Boyle 2004). While one may argue that a brand that is perceived to be an imitation of an exemplar brand is a false or dishonest brand, it is unclear if the anthropomorphized trait exists within the conceptual domain of brand authenticity. The definition of honesty in Table 1 defines the dimension as the avoidance of all forms of dishonesty. Avoiding dishonesty and being honest are distinct, but related, concepts. By definition, an exemplar is not a copy. But avoiding being a copy of something else does not necessarily make one a model that others will use as a basis for imitation. Being an exemplar excludes imitators and, therefore, renders the poorly-conceived honest dimension moot because it is not needed to cover the conceptual domain of brand authenticity.

The dimension, originality, refers to whether the brand has introduced something new and unique to the market. It refers to a brand's particularity, individuality, and innovativeness (Authentic Brand Index 2008; Bruhn et al. 2012; Gilmore and Pine 2007). The central meaning of this definition is that originality is similar to unique. To be original, the brand object (1) introduced something new and unique to the market and (2) remains distinctive. One flaw with this conceptualization is that it refers to a commercial brand object. However, brand objects are not necessarily bought and sold like consumer products (for example, a charity can be a brand object). Bringing something new and unique to the market is problematic. The IBM Simon Personal Communicator was the first or original smartphone (IBM Simon 2016). It meets the definition of the originality dimension. However, it is not considered to be the authentic smartphone. This honor belongs to the iPhone, as discussed previously. An authentic brand may be the pioneer in its category, but it does not have to be the pioneer to be an authentic brand. Hence, originality (as defined in the brand authenticity literature) is not a valid brand authenticity dimension.

The dimension, naturalness, refers to a brand's impression of genuineness, realness, and lack of artificiality (Bruhn et al. 2012). The denotative meaning of naturalness refers to a property of existing, or being formed, in nature (Naturalness 2016). Hence, there is a lack of congruence between the denotation of naturalness and the way in which it has been defined for this context. We do acknowledge, however, that there is a relationship between the denotative meaning of authenticity and genuineness, realness, and lack of artificiality.

The word genuine is often used in the definition of authentic and authentic is often used in the definition of genuine. It addresses the idea that something authentic is the real (not a counterfeit or imitation) version of something. It's best to define something in terms of what it is rather than what it is not. If a brand object is perceived to be an exemplar, it is, by definition, not an imitation of something else. If a brand object is an exemplar, it is an ideal example of its type. It is the typical example of its type; it is a model or pattern to be copied or imitated (Exemplar 2016). Likewise, if a brand object is perceived to be the quintessence of its kind, it is perceived to be the most perfect embodiment of its kind (Quintessence 2016). Hence, for something to be perceived to be authentic refers to the degree to which it is perceived to be the quintessential exemplar of its type. The iPhone has a high degree of brand authenticity because it is perceived to be the best example of a smartphone, the distinctive brand others imitate, the standard to which other smartphones are compared.

4 Reconceptualizing brand authenticity

In contrast to the multidimensional theory of brand authenticity in the extant literature, our conceptualization of brand authenticity is unidimensional. We define brand authenticity as the degree to which a brand object is perceived to be the quintessential exemplar of its type. This definition is congruent with the denotation of authenticity and it can apply to all types of brand objects, a characteristic of valid construct conceptualizations (Wymer 2016). Being a unidimensional construct means that it cannot be conflated with another construct due to placing a proximate member of the construct's nomological net in the construct's conceptual domain.

Measuring brand authenticity can be easily accomplished by using three or four reflective indicators of the construct. Future research is needed to develop and validate an appropriate scale for brand authenticity. Possible scale items might include the following:

1. XXX is the best example of its kind.
2. XXX is the one that serves as a comparison for others of its kind.
3. XXX is the most imitated of its kind.

With respect to the iPhone, the scales could be modified as follows: (1) The iPhone is the best example of a smartphone; (2) The iPhone is the smartphone that serves as a comparison for other smartphones; and (3) The iPhone is the most imitated smartphone. Using a nonprofit organization as our brand object, the scales could be modified as follows: (1) The Red Cross is the best example of a disaster relief organization; (2) The Red Cross is the disaster relief organization

that serves as a comparison for other disaster relief organizations; and (3) The Red Cross is the most imitated disaster relief organization.

With respect to predicting brand authenticity, it is reasonable to believe that brand strength has an influence on brand authenticity. Brand strength refers to the degree to which a brand is well known, perceived favorably, and perceived to be remarkable in comparison to peer brands (Wymer et al. 2016). The extent to which brand strength influences brand authenticity will be better understood in future research.

It is reasonable to believe that brand strength is predictive of some desirable outcome variables. What is the relationship between brand strength, brand authenticity, and desired outcome variables? Is the effect of brand strength on target outcome variables mediated or moderated by brand authenticity? Future research is needed to help us understand these important marketing relationships better.

4.1 Brand authenticity, brand values, and brand personality

Brand authenticity has some overlap in the literature with brand values and brand personality. Future research which continues to develop the theory of brand authenticity should further explicate the relationships among these constructs.

All three brand constructs (authenticity, personality, and values) can be useful by certain individuals as a vehicle of self-expression and ego enhancement (Malär et al. 2011). A key concept in this research stream is self-congruence, which refers to the degree to which there is a fit between an individual's self and the brand's personality or image (Aaker 1999). Brand personality attributes human characteristics or traits to a brand object. The same can be said for brand authenticity and brand values. Aaker (1997) identified five dimensions of brand personality: sincerity, excitement, competence, sophistication, and ruggedness. Subsequent research has added additional brand personality dimensions, like social responsibility (Madrigal and Boush 2008). Brand authenticity is positioned as a brand personality dimension (Napoli et al. 2014).

Some researchers have construed authenticity as emblematic of a brand's deeply-held, noncommercial values (Holt 2002; Morhart et al. 2014). In our analysis, we found this construal and use of perceived authenticity to be synonymous with deeply-held noncommercial values to be a source of invalidity in the theoretical construction of brand authenticity. Researchers making the argument that link authenticity with brand core values that are not commercially motivated were working within an inadvertent corporate-consumer paradigm. This problem is one of the reasons this article is important to nonprofit marketing researchers—brand authenticity is conceived in a manner that is relevant across brand object types, making our conception valid for nonprofit marketing scholars.

5 Implications for nonprofit marketing research

There are distinctions between branding in the nonprofit sector and branding in the commercial sector that make nonprofit branding more complex and worthy of a dedicated program of research. Marketers of consumer brands seek to stimulate consumer brand preference to increase competitiveness. A corporation's reputation and the brand images of its consumer products are distinct. A nonprofit's

reputation and its brand image are inherently combined. In a sense, the nonprofit's reputation is the brand. A for-profit business exists to increase the wealth of its owners. The business, thus, focuses on increasing profits by increasing prices, increasing sales, and reducing competition. A nonprofit has no owners and exists to fulfill its mission. A business focuses on stimulating a preference for its brand from a target group of consumers. A nonprofit has multiple stakeholder groups from whom it cultivates relationships and seeks support.

Furthermore, the relationship between consumer and brand in the commercial setting is often transactional or value exchange. That is, consumers exchange money for the benefits that consuming the product provides them. It is essentially an economic and an egoistic relationship. The relationship between nonprofit supporter (e.g., donor, volunteer) and brand in the nonprofit setting is often value expressive. That is, supporters give their money or time to the nonprofit organization from an intrinsic motivation to act in accord with their core values. It is essentially a noneconomic and an altruistic relationship.

The research stream involving the brand authenticity construct has flaws and nonprofit marketing scholars should exercise caution with working with this construct. When nonprofit marketing scholars are developing a research program that extends prior research on marketing constructs, they should make sure that the constructs are conceptualized in a valid manner. To assess the degree to which a construct has been validity conceived, the validity issues presented in this paper can serve as a guide.

First, the way in which a construct has been defined should be consistent with the denotation of the construct's name. If it is not, then the definition should be changed for congruency with the denotation of the construct's name or the construct should be given a name synonymous with its definition/meaning. If there is no close semantic association between the meaning of a proposed construct and a word in the formal language, the researcher should invent a unique word for that construct.

Second, the definition should be parsimonious and precise. The definition of a construct should be sufficient to cover the meaning within the boundaries of its conceptual domain without expanding beyond those borders. The definition should describe the meaning of the construct, but only that construct.

Third, the definition of the construct should apply to all relevant contexts. The validity of research in marketing has often been compromised by this problem (Wymer 2013a). Often researchers have had consumer products or services in mind when they define constructs or develop their scales. The brand authenticity research is an example of this error. If brand authenticity is a quality that can exist for any type of brand object, then the construct should be defined in such a way that all types of brand objects are included. Nonprofit marketers, especially, should be sure to redefine constructs with which they work to correct for this source of invalidity.

Finally, the construct's definition should not include an antecedent (or other construct from its nomological net). A construct's definition should only refers to its meaning and it should not include the meaning of an additional construct. Take special care when evaluating the conceptualization of a multidimensional construct. Make sure that the dimensions are necessary and sufficient facets of the higher order construct. Make sure that the measurement model is a first order reflective and second order formative model for multidimensional constructs.

6 Conclusion

Careless research results in a literature that adds little but confusion to our understanding of marketing phenomena (Jacoby 1978). Poorly conceptualized constructs are a major source of such work. Brand authenticity is an example of the unintended consequences of poorly conceived constructs. Subsequent research fragments rather than extends the research stream. Poorly conceived constructs lead to confusion and disunity rather than knowledge discovery and scientific consensus.

The name assigned to a construct should be consistent with its denotation. A validity problem is indicated when the name of a construct has two meanings, one according to the formal language (denotation) and one assigned by a researcher. Marketing researchers should avoid using jargon to name constructs but should instead use the most appropriate word from the formal language.

The definition of a construct should be as precise and parsimonious as possible. The definition should be sufficient to define the construct's meaning (conceptual domain) without describing facets of other constructs.

Even though brand authenticity is a relatively emergent construct, the body of work on the construct has been considerably weakened by its initial problematic conceptualizations. Researchers have not been reluctant to add dimensions to brand authenticity if they believed it suited the contexts of their research studies. As a consequence, we know little about the brand authenticity construct and its nomological relationships.

In this paper, we have analyzed the literature on brand authenticity and concluded that brand authenticity is a unidimensional construct that refers to the degree to which a brand object is perceived to be the quintessential exemplar of its type. This definition is precise and parsimonious. It is congruent with the denotation of authenticity. We hope this can be used to enhance the validity of future work on brand authenticity.

Appendix A. Literature searching procedures from Akbar (2016)

In order to identify and gather the necessary literature, multiple databases including Science Direct, Google Scholar, SAGE Journals Online, Business Source Complete, ProQuest Science Journals, JSTOR, Web of Science Core Collection, Elsevier, EBSCO, and ABI/INFORM Global were used. The following keywords were used for the search: Brand authenticity, Authenticity of brand, Authentic brand(s), Authentic branding, Authenticity defined, Typologies (types) of authenticity, Conceptualization of brand authenticity, Brand authenticity conceptualized, Brand authenticity scale, Revisiting the conceptualization of brand authenticity, Confirmatory factor analysis of brand authenticity scale, Interpretations of authenticity in different fields, Applicability of brand authenticity to commercial and/or non-profit brands, etc.

In the initial stages, the aforementioned databases were used to download suitable articles and for that reason, the search was not restricted to any given time frame, to ensure that any relevant article did not go undetected. In addition, many relevant articles were downloaded from a number of journals including Journal of Business Research, Journal of Brand Management, Advances in Consumer Research, Journal of Consumer Psychology, European Journal of Marketing, Journal of Marketing, Marketing Management, Journal of Product & Brand Management, Psychology & Marketing,

Journal of Management Studies, The Academy of Management Journal, Academy of Management Review, Journal of Applied Psychology, Annals of Tourism Research, and Tourism Management.

In the later stages of this process, the search was reduced to articles emerging between 1980 and 2014 and the suitable articles were reviewed from these findings, taking into consideration the titles, abstracts, and articles by selective reading. This search generated approximately 30 articles that are relevant to BA, and out of those only 5 or 6 were found to be pertinent to the conceptualization of BA.

Additionally, two PhD dissertations and three Master's theses on brand authenticity were identified from the search. Of those dissertations, one by Coary (2013) seemed to be quite relevant and original addressing the conceptualization of BA. Of several books uncovered on Authenticity or BA, three were found to be relevant to the purpose of this study, from Boyle (2004), Gilmore and Pine (2007), and Beverland (2009). The first two books were considered to be the most relevant to the conceptualization of BA. The website created by Authentic Brand Index (2008) was also found to be pertinent to the study. Some studies related to "Organizational authenticity" as well as "Authentic leadership" were also identified. Those articles provided an idea about authenticity in general, but yielded nothing more conclusive. Interestingly, a number of articles on authenticity were found to be relevant to tourism, which were helpful in enriching an understanding of authenticity in a business-like context. Perhaps the most pertinent article on brand authenticity was Beverland's (2006) article focusing on the authenticity of luxury wine brands. Several articles and a book were also found that addressed typologies and diversity in interpretations of authenticity. From this literature search and review, only several resources could be extrapolated to a reasonable extent in order to conceptualize BA.

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